

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS DOCUMENT

Circles

Connect with people you know. Discover people you haven't met yet.

Version	3.0 — Definitive Two-Pillar Release
Status	Draft — For Developer Review
Date	April 2026
Platform	iOS & Android (React Native)
Author	Product Team
Confidentiality	Internal — Do Not Distribute

Prepared for the Engineering & Design Team

1. Executive Summary

Circles is a mobile-first social app built around two distinct but complementary modes of human connection. The first mode is for people who already know each other — friends, family, office colleagues — and need a dedicated, private space to chat, plan outings, and share memories. The second mode is for strangers in a shared context — passengers on the same train, walkers in the same park, travellers on the same flight — who want company and conversation without ever exchanging phone numbers.

Most apps optimise for one of these modes. WhatsApp is for people you already know. Bumble BFF or Meetup is for strangers. Circles is the only app that serves both — with a clean separation between the two surfaces — inside a single product identity.

The privacy design is central to the product's value: Circles allows two strangers to connect, chat, plan, and meet in real life based purely on a shared context (same train, same neighbourhood, same hobby) without either person revealing a phone number, email, or any personal identifier they have not chosen to share.

Pillar 1 — Private Circles

Invite-only groups for people who already know each other. Friends, family, colleagues. Coordinate plans, chat, video call, split expenses, and build shared memories — all in one place.

Pillar 2 — Open Discovery

Public circle cards visible on the app's landing feed. Any user can post a card to find fellow travellers, hobby partners, or neighbours. Anyone can join — no phone number exchange, ever.

2. Problem Statement

2.1 The Gaps in Today's Apps

Close friend groups are fragmented across tools. A typical group of 8 friends uses WhatsApp for messages, Google Maps to pick a restaurant, Splitwise for bills, and a calendar app to find a date. None of these tools know the group exists as a social unit.

Stranger-connection has a bigger gap. There is no safe, low-friction way for two people in a shared physical context — a train journey, a morning jog, a concert queue — to say "I'd like some company" without handing over a personal contact. Every existing option (asking for a phone number, following on Instagram) carries a significant social and privacy cost.

2.2 Target Users

User Type	Description	Key Need
School / college group	Ages 16–25; high app adoption; strong group identity	Private coordination — outings, trips, hangouts
Working professional gang	Ages 25–40; busy schedules; disposable income	Low-effort planning; expense splitting
Family circle	Ages 30–55; multi-generational; casual coordination	Shared memories; trip planning; photo sharing
Solo traveller	Any age; on trains, flights, buses; open to connection	Meet co-passengers safely, no number exchange
Hobbyist / interest seeker	Any age; runner, musician, birder, foodie	Find like-minded people in their city or area
Newcomer to a city	Age 22–35; relocated for work or study	Build a social circle from scratch without awkwardness

2.3 Core Design Insight

The No-Phone-Number Principle

In both Pillar 1 and Pillar 2, users never need to share a phone number to connect. Private circle invites go via a shareable link (WhatsApp, email, any channel). Open circle joins happen inside the app. Identity is app-level only — first name, avatar, and optional bio. A user controls exactly what they reveal.

2.4 Success Metrics

Metric	Definition	6-Month Target
Monthly Active Users	Users who open the app at least once in 30 days	> 75,000 MAU
Private circle creation	% of new installs that create or join a private circle	> 65%
Open Feed join rate	% of users who view an Open Feed card and join that circle	> 14%
Stranger-to-plan rate	Open Feed circles that generate at least one planner event	> 30%
Day-7 retention	Users returning 7 days after first install	> 42%
Circles per active user	Average circles (private + open) a user belongs to	> 2.5
Phone-number-free sessions	Sessions where user communicates without revealing phone number	100% by design
Premium conversion	Free users who upgrade to Circles+	> 5%

3. Product Vision & Principles

Circles is the app for every kind of human circle — the ones you were born into, the ones you chose, and the ones you haven't discovered yet. It is a coordination layer for the offline world: every feature exists to make a real-world moment easier to plan, safer to initiate, or more memorable to keep.

Principle	What It Means in Practice
Privacy by architecture	No phone number is ever exchanged between users inside the app. Identity is first name + avatar only. Users choose what to share beyond that.
Context-first connection	Strangers connect through shared context (same train, same interest, same location) — not through profile browsing. Context is the icebreaker.
Zero-friction planning	Creating a plan — dinner, movie, trip — takes under 30 seconds. The planner is the core value loop, not a bolt-on feature.
Private by default	Private circles are fully invite-only. Open circles are visible publicly, but chat and member details remain internal to members only.
Offline-tolerant	Plans, messages, and circle data are cached locally. The app remains useful on a slow train with 2G connectivity.
No lock-in via numbers	Because no phone number is shared, users feel safe joining circles with strangers. This is the fundamental unlock for Pillar 2.

4. Pillar 1 — Private Circles

Private Circles are invite-only groups for people who already share a relationship. The creator names the circle, sets a context, and shares an invite link through any channel they choose — WhatsApp, email, SMS, AirDrop — without the app mandating any particular sharing method.

4.1 Circle Types

Circle Type	Description & Typical Use
Friends	School gang, college hostel group, childhood friends. Chat, plan outings, watch parties, birthday surprises.
Family	Nuclear family, extended family, cousins group. Trip planning, photo sharing, birthday coordination.
Office / Work	Team lunches, after-work outings, project celebration dinners. Separate from professional tools — this is social.
Custom	Any label the creator chooses — 'Book Club', 'Running Crew', 'Roommates 2024'. No restriction on type.

4.2 Creating a Private Circle

1. Tap '+' on the Circles tab and choose 'Private Circle'
2. Enter a circle name (required) and optional tagline
3. Choose or upload a circle photo, or pick from illustrated presets
4. App generates a unique invite link (e.g. circles.app/join/abc123)
5. Creator shares the link via any channel — WhatsApp, email, DM, QR code, or link copy
6. Link recipient taps it, downloads the app if needed, completes OTP verification, and is instantly added
7. Creator receives a notification when each person joins

No Phone Number Exchange

The invite link is the mechanism — not a phone number. The person receiving the link never sees the creator's phone number during or after the join process. App-level identity (first name + avatar) is all that is visible unless members choose to share more in chat.

4.3 Roles & Permissions

Role	Capabilities	How Assigned
Admin	Rename circle, remove members, revoke invite links, archive circle, promote others to admin	Creator is admin by default; can promote any member
Member	Chat, create plans, RSVP, upload photos, vote on polls, add expenses	Automatically assigned on join
Guest	Read-only access to chat and plans; cannot create content	Admin can invite as Guest (Circles+ only)

4.4 Chat & Communication

4.4.1 Messaging

- Text messages with full Unicode and multi-language support
- Emoji picker with skin tone variants and recently used section
- GIF search via Giphy / Tenor API integration
- Tap-hold any message to react with an emoji
- Swipe-to-reply — inline reply threads within the chat
- Delete for me / delete for everyone (within 5 minutes)
- Unread badge and message delivery indicators (sent / delivered / seen by all)

4.4.2 Video Calls

- Initiate a group video call from the circle — all members receive a push notification
- Supports up to 12 participants simultaneously
- Peer-to-peer via WebRTC — call audio and video never pass through or are stored on Circles servers

- Local recording: call initiator can record; recording saves to device camera roll on call end
- Explicit prompt on call end: 'Save recording to your device?' — opt-in, not automatic
- No cloud backup of recordings under any circumstances — privacy by architecture
- In-call controls: mute self, toggle camera, speaker, flip camera, participant grid, end call

4.5 The Planner

The Planner is the feature that separates Circles from a plain messaging app. It is a structured event coordination layer embedded directly in each circle.

4.5.1 Plan Types

Type	Fields	Smart Suggestions
Meal	Date, time, meal type (breakfast/lunch/dinner), venue name or search, head count	Restaurants via Zomato / Google Places API
Movie	Date, time, film title, cinema, optional booking link	Now-showing titles via TMDB API
Trip	Destination, departure & return dates, rough budget per person, notes	Hotels & transport via affiliate links
Custom	Title, date, time, optional location, optional notes	None — free-form

4.5.2 Plan Lifecycle

8. Creator drafts the plan and publishes it to the circle — a plan card appears in chat and in the Planner tab
9. All members receive a push notification: '[Name] created a plan — [Plan title] on [Date]'
10. Members tap the card to RSVP: Going / Maybe / Can't make it
11. Creator sees a live RSVP count; can tap 'Nudge non-responders' to send a gentle reminder
12. 24 hours before the event: automatic reminder notification to Going and Maybe members
13. Day of the event: optional opt-in real-time location sharing among Going members only
14. Post-event: plan archived; members prompted to add photos — photos link to the plan in Memory Lane

4.5.3 Availability Check

- Before creating a plan, creator can send an availability poll: 'Who's free this weekend?'
- Members tap dates on a simple calendar grid to mark availability
- Creator sees a visual overlap summary — best dates highlighted in green
- Tap any date to instantly create a plan with available members pre-populated as Going

4.6 Polls

- Any member can post a poll in the chat

- Poll types: single choice, multiple choice, or 1–5 star rating
- Results shown as real-time percentage bars as votes come in
- Creator can close the poll and pin the result as a chat message
- Quick-poll templates: 'Where should we eat?', 'Which movie?', 'What time?'

4.7 Memory Lane

- Shared photo gallery per circle — separate from chat scroll
- Photos tagged to a plan if uploaded within 48 hours of the event date
- Scrollable gallery view, filterable by month or plan
- Members can add captions and emoji reactions to photos
- Annual 'Year in Circles' recap auto-generated every December (Circles+ feature)

4.8 Expense Splitting

- Add an expense: amount, who paid, split equally or by custom amounts among selected members
- Running balance always visible: 'You owe Arjun ₹450' / 'Priya owes you ₹200'
- Settle up: generates a deep link to GPay/PhonePe/Paytm with amount pre-filled — one tap to pay
- Expense history archived per plan and viewable for the full circle lifetime
- No in-app payment processing — settlement is delegated to trusted UPI apps

5. Pillar 2 — Open Discovery (Stranger Circles)

Open Discovery is the landing surface of the Circles app. It is a scrollable, public feed of circle cards — posted by users who want to meet strangers around a shared context. Any user who downloads the app sees this feed immediately, without needing to be in a private circle.

The fundamental mechanic is context-first connection. A user does not browse a directory of people. They browse a directory of shared situations — a train journey, a morning walking route, a music interest, a neighbourhood. The situation is the social introduction. No phone number, no personal identifier beyond a first name and avatar, is ever shared between strangers.

The Zero-Number Promise

Two strangers can find each other on the Open Feed, join the same circle, chat, plan to meet, and share a meal on a train — and neither ever learns the other's phone number unless they choose to share it in conversation. This is not a privacy setting. It is how the architecture works.

5.1 The Open Feed

The Open Feed is the first tab a user sees when they open the app. It is a vertically scrollable list of public circle cards, ordered by a relevance algorithm that considers:

- Location proximity (circles near the user's current city or GPS location)
- Travel context (transit circles matching a train/flight/bus the user has searched or recently used)
- Join velocity (circles gaining members quickly in the last 24 hours)
- Category affinity (circles similar to those the user has joined before)

5.2 Open Circle Card Anatomy

Field	Description
Circle name	Short, descriptive — e.g. 'Morning Walkers — Indiranagar' or '12163 Chennai Express — 14 April'
Category tag	One of: Travel & Transit / Fitness / Music & Arts / Food & Dining / Hobby / Neighbourhood / Professional / Other
Pitch / headline	1–2 sentences written by the creator: who they are and who they want in the circle
Context details	Location (city / area) for interest circles, OR transit details (train/flight/bus number + date) for travel circles
Member count	Live count of how many people have joined — auto-updated
Creator info	First name + avatar only — no phone number, no social handle visible
Join / Request CTA	One tap to join (Open circles) or request to join (Approval circles)
Tags	Up to 5 keywords set by creator — e.g. #6am #running #koramangala #beginner
Time posted	Relative timestamp — '2 hours ago', 'Today', 'Yesterday'

5.3 Creating an Open Circle

Any registered user can post an open circle card from the Open Feed tab. The creation flow is a 5-step guided form:

15. Choose category — Travel & Transit, Fitness, Music & Arts, Food & Dining, Hobby, Neighbourhood, Professional, Other
16. Name the circle and write a 1–2 sentence pitch
17. Add context: for Travel circles — select mode (Train / Flight / Bus), enter route identifier and travel date; for Interest circles — add city and optional neighbourhood or landmark
18. Add up to 5 hashtag keywords
19. Choose join mode: Open (anyone joins instantly) or Approval Required (creator approves each request)

On submission the card is published to the Open Feed and visible immediately to other users. The creator becomes the circle admin and can moderate and archive the circle at any time.

5.4 Transit Circles — The Train / Flight / Bus Use Case

Transit circles are a flagship use case for Pillar 2. A person about to embark on a long journey can post a card to find co-passengers — for conversation, a shared meal, a card game, or simply company on a late-night train.

5.4.1 How a Transit Circle Works

20. User opens the Open Feed and taps 'Create Circle'
21. Selects category: Travel & Transit
22. Selects mode: Train — enters train number (e.g. 12163 for Chennai Express) and travel date
23. Writes a short pitch: 'Travelling alone from Chennai to Mumbai — happy to chat, share snacks, play cards. Kids welcome.'
24. Publishes the card — it appears in the Open Feed immediately
25. Other passengers on the same train search or scroll and find the card — they see the train number, date, and the pitch
26. They tap 'Join' — they are in the circle, can chat in the group, and can share their coach/seat number voluntarily
27. The circle chat becomes a live travel companion channel for the duration of the journey
28. 24 hours after the travel date, the transit circle auto-archives — it disappears from the Open Feed
29. Members are prompted: 'Your journey is over. Keep this circle as a memory or let it go?'

5.4.2 Transit Circle Discovery

- Users can search the Open Feed directly by train number, flight number (IATA format), or bus route
- Search results show all active transit circles matching that route on the selected date
- 'Today's trains near you' section on the Open Feed home — proactive suggestion based on GPS city
- Push notification trigger: if a user has previously searched a train route, the app notifies them when a circle is posted for that route

5.4.3 Transit Circle Privacy

- Neither the card nor the circle chat shows the creator's phone number at any point
- Members' coach and seat numbers are never collected or stored by the app — if shared, it is in the chat voluntarily
- Transit circles are read-only to non-members — only the card (name, pitch, route, member count) is public
- Members can leave a transit circle at any time; their past messages remain but show as '[Member left]'

5.5 Interest & Neighbourhood Circles

Beyond travel, the Open Feed supports any interest or location-based circle. Examples:

Real-World Scenario	What the Open Circle Card Looks Like
A violinist wants to meet other classical musicians in Bengaluru	Name: 'Violin & Strings — Bengaluru' Category: Music & Arts Pitch: 'Looking for fellow violinists or string players in Bangalore for informal jam sessions on weekends.' Tags: #violin #classical #weekend
A morning walker wants walking companions in their area	Name: 'Morning Walkers — Koramangala 6AM' Category: Fitness Pitch: 'I walk every day 6–7am around the Koramangala inner ring road. Looking for a walking partner or small group.' Tags: #morningwalk #6am #koramangala
A solo traveller wants to find others on their flight	Name: 'IndiGo 6E 456 — Bengaluru to Delhi — 15 Apr' Category: Travel Pitch: 'Window seat, travelling solo. Happy to share a cab from the airport if anyone's heading to South Delhi.' Tags: #6E456 #bangalore #delhi
A film fan wants to find others to watch a new release	Name: 'Pushpa 2 Opening Night — PVR Koramangala' Category: Food & Dining / Hobby Pitch: 'Going for the 9pm show on Friday — who else? Let's grab dinner before and make a night of it.' Tags: #pushpa2 #pvr #openingnight
A newcomer wants to build a social circle	Name: 'New in Bengaluru — Jan 2026 Batch' Category: Neighbourhood Pitch: 'Relocated for work, looking to meet people my age (25–30) in Indiranagar or HSR. Up for coffee or weekend plans.' Tags: #newcity #indiranagar #25to30

5.6 Joining an Open Circle

- Open circle: tap 'Join' on the feed card — user is immediately added as a member and enters the circle chat
- Approval circle: tap 'Request to Join' — creator receives a notification and approves or declines
- On joining, the chat shows: '[First name] joined the circle' — no phone number visible
- Members see each other's first names and avatars only — no contact information is surfaced
- Any member can share the circle card externally via link — shared link opens the Open Feed card in the app
- Users can preview a card (read the pitch and see member count) without joining

5.7 Feed Filtering & Search

Filter Type	Options	Behaviour
Category	All / Travel & Transit / Fitness / Music & Arts / Food & Dining / Hobby / Neighbourhood / Professional	Single-select; filters feed in real time
Location	'Near me' (GPS), or type any city, area, or landmark	Narrows to circles with matching location context
Transit	Search by train number, flight code, or bus route number + travel date	Returns transit circles matching that route on that date

Filter Type	Options	Behaviour
Keyword	Free text search across circle names, pitches, and tags	Fuzzy match; returns ranked results
Sort	Relevance (default) / Newest / Most members / Most active	User can override ranking with explicit sort preference

5.8 Moderation & Safety

5.8.1 Automated Layer

- Profanity and hate-speech filter on circle name, pitch, and tags — submission blocked if triggered
- Duplicate detection: same user cannot post near-identical cards within 24 hours
- Spam throttle: maximum 3 open circle cards per user per 24 hours
- Bot detection: accounts less than 24 hours old cannot post open circles without phone OTP re-verification

5.8.2 Community Reporting

- Every card has a 'Report' button — options: Spam, Inappropriate content, Misleading, Harassment
- Cards receiving 5 or more reports in 24 hours are auto-hidden pending manual review
- Reporter receives a notification within 48 hours of the outcome

5.8.3 Admin Moderation Dashboard

- Internal web tool for the Circles moderation team to review flagged cards
- Actions available: Approve (reinstate), Remove card, Warn user, Suspend user (7-day or permanent)
- All actions logged with timestamp, moderator ID, and reason for audit trail
- SLA target: flagged content reviewed within 2 hours during 8am–10pm IST

5.8.4 In-Circle Safety

- Any member can remove themselves from a circle at any time
- Any member can block another member — blocking prevents that user from joining any circle the blocker creates
- Admin can remove any member from the circle
- Transit circles auto-archive 24 hours after journey date — reducing window for misuse

6. User Identity & Onboarding

Circles uses a minimal identity model. The goal is to give each user enough identity to be trusted and recognisable within their circles, while never exposing data they have not chosen to share.

6.1 Registration Flow

30. Download app → Enter mobile number → Receive OTP → Verified
31. Choose a display name (first name only, or any name the user wants) — this is shown to other circle members
32. Upload a profile photo or choose a generated avatar
33. Optional: add a short bio (max 80 characters) — visible to circle members only
34. App prompts: 'What brings you to Circles?' — three options to personalise first-run experience: 'Connect with my people', 'Meet new people', or 'Both'

6.2 Identity Visibility Rules

Data Point	Who Can See It	Notes
Mobile number	No one except Circles backend for authentication	Never surfaced in UI to any user
Display name	All members of circles they belong to	User-chosen; default is first name
Profile photo	All members of circles they belong to	User can remove at any time
Short bio	All members of circles they belong to	Optional; 80 char max
Join date	Visible on Open Feed card creator info	Year only — e.g. 'Member since 2026'
Circles joined	Not visible to anyone	Private by architecture
Activity status	Not shown by default; opt-in to show 'Active now'	User setting

7. Technical Architecture

7.1 Recommended Stack

Layer	Technology	Rationale
Mobile app	React Native (Expo managed workflow)	Single codebase for iOS & Android; strong community; Expo EAS for OTA updates
Private chat backend	Firebase Realtime Database or Stream Chat SDK	Real-time messaging; scales to millions; no need to build WebSocket infra from scratch

Layer	Technology	Rationale
Open Feed backend	Cloud Firestore (NoSQL document store)	Flexible schema for feed cards; real-time listeners; efficient querying by location and category
Feed ranking	Cloud Function — join velocity + location + affinity score	Lightweight scoring; no ML required at MVP scale; can be upgraded to ML later
Video calls	Daily.co SDK or Jitsi Meet SDK (self-hosted option)	WebRTC peer-to-peer; no media passes through Circles servers; supports 12-participant group calls
Local call recording	MediaRecorder API (React Native device-side)	Recording happens entirely on the initiator's device; never uploaded
Push notifications	Firebase Cloud Messaging (FCM)	Single service covers iOS (via APNs relay) and Android; free at scale
Authentication	Firebase Auth — Phone OTP + Google Sign-In	Frictionless; no email required; phone number confirmed but never shown to other users
Location services	Google Maps Geocoding API + device GPS	Neighbourhood-level geocoding for Open Feed; reverse geocode user location to city/area
Transit data	Indian Railways API (RailYatri / IRCTC) + IATA flight lookup	Train and flight number validation for transit circles; prevents fake route tags
Media storage	AWS S3 or Firebase Storage with per-circle IAM rules	Photos and GIFs; no call recordings stored
Restaurant suggestions	Zomato Affiliate API / Google Places API	Venue search and rating data in Planner meal type
Movie data	TMDB API (free tier)	Now-showing titles for Planner movie type; covers India releases
UPI settlement	Deep links to GPay / PhonePe / Paytm	No payment gateway integration needed; delegates to trusted apps
Content moderation	Google Perspective API + internal dashboard	Auto-score Open Feed submissions; flag high-toxicity content before publish

7.2 Data Architecture & Privacy

- Mobile numbers are stored in Firebase Auth only — they never appear in the Firestore database as queryable fields
- Private circle data (messages, plans, photos) stored under /circles/{circleId} — access rules allow only confirmed members
- Open Feed cards stored under /public_circles/{cardId} — readable by any authenticated user, writable only by card creator
- No cross-collection query ever returns a user's phone number to another user
- Location stored at city/neighbourhood granularity only — raw GPS coordinates are used transiently for geocoding and then discarded
- Transit circle documents include only: route identifier, travel date, creator display name, member list (display names only)
- GDPR-compliant: full data export and account deletion available in Settings; deletion cascades across all collections

7.3 Offline Behaviour

- Last 100 messages per circle cached locally using AsyncStorage or SQLite
- Planner events, RSVPs, and Open Feed cards cached for offline reading
- Draft messages queued locally; sent automatically on reconnection
- Open Feed cards load from cache when offline — joined circles shown first, discovery feed shows last-loaded results

7.4 Performance Targets

Operation	Target Latency	Measurement Condition
App cold start	< 2 seconds	Mid-range Android (Snapdragon 665) on 4G
Chat message delivery	< 500ms	Firebase Realtime DB round trip on 4G
Open Feed initial load	< 1.5 seconds	First 10 cards from Firestore on 4G
Image upload (chat)	< 3 seconds	2MB JPEG on 4G; progressive thumbnail in < 1s
RSVP update propagation	< 2 seconds	All circle members see update within 2s of tap
Transit circle search	< 1 second	Train number + date query on Firestore

8. Phased Delivery Roadmap

Both Pillar 1 (Private Circles) and Pillar 2 (Open Discovery) ship together from Phase 1. Open Discovery is not a later addition — it is the primary acquisition and onboarding surface for new users who have not yet been invited to a private circle.

Phase	Timeline	Scope	Primary Goal
Phase 1 MVP	Month 1–3	Private Circles: creation, WhatsApp invite link, group chat (text + emoji + GIF), basic Planner (meal / movie / trip), RSVP, push notifications. Open Discovery: Open Feed landing screen, circle card creation, category + location + transit search, join / request-to-join, transit circles with auto-archive, basic content moderation (profanity filter + report).	Prove both loops work: private groups coordinate plans; strangers find each other without sharing phone numbers.
Phase 2 Depth	Month 4–6	Video calls with local download, polls, availability check, Memory Lane, expense splitting with UPI deep links, message reactions & reply threads. Open Feed: personalised feed ranking, feed keyword search, push alerts for matching transit circles, in-circle safety (block, leave, remove member), admin moderation dashboard.	Drive 30-day retention; prove Open Feed generates real-world meetups.
Phase 3 Monetisation	Month 7–9	Circles+ subscription, plan boosts, restaurant affiliate integration, Annual Year-in-Circles Recap. Open Feed: promoted circle card placements, verified badge for organisations, college and enterprise admin dashboard, IRCTC / MakeMyTrip transit affiliate links.	Hit > 5% premium conversion; first Open Feed B2B revenue.

9. Monetisation Strategy

Circles operates a freemium model with five revenue streams. The free tier is deliberately generous — both Private Circles and Open Discovery are fully functional at no cost. Premium features target high-frequency users, active circles, and organisations.

9.1 Free vs. Circles+ Premium

Feature	Free Tier	Circles+ (₹99–199/month or ₹799/year)
Private circles	1 active circle	Unlimited
Members per private circle	Up to 15	Up to 50
Open Feed cards posted	Up to 2 active at a time	Unlimited

Feature	Free Tier	Circles+ (₹99–199/month or ₹799/year)
Photo memory storage	100 photos / circle	5 GB / circle
Video call duration	30 minutes per call	Unlimited
Local call recording	Not available	Enabled
Circle themes & icons	3 presets	20+ themes + custom upload
Guest (read-only) members	Not available	Up to 5 per circle
Annual 'Year in Circles' recap	Not available	Included every December
Plan boost features	Standard fields only	Packing list, countdown, booking links
Priority support	Help centre FAQ	Email + in-app live support

9.2 Revenue Streams

Stream	Mechanism	Price Point	Target
Circles+	Monthly / annual subscription via App Store / Play Store IAP	₹99–199/mo or ₹799/yr	Active users in frequent circles
Plan Boosts	One-time in-app purchase per planner event	₹29–49 per plan	Users planning trips or special occasions
Restaurant Affiliate	Commission on Zomato / Google Maps bookings placed via app	8–15% per completed order	Metro users using the Planner meal type
Open Feed Promoted Cards	CPM / CPC native placements in Open Feed	₹500–2,000 per 1,000 impressions	Local businesses, event organisers, clubs, gyms
Enterprise / Campus	B2B monthly licence — admin dashboard + branded circles	₹999–4,999/month per organisation	Colleges, corporate HR teams, sports clubs

9.3 Open Feed Monetisation Detail

- Promoted Cards are native — they look identical to organic circle cards with a small 'Promoted' label. They appear at position 3 and 8 in the feed to minimise disruption.
- Verified Badge (blue tick): paid annual fee for verified organisations — colleges, NGOs, registered clubs — who want members to trust their card is authentic. Fee: ₹1,999–4,999/year depending on organisation size.
- Transit Affiliate: when a user views a transit circle for a train or flight, the app surfaces an IRCTC or MakeMyTrip booking link with the route pre-filled. Commission on completed bookings.
- Event Partnerships: local event organisers (concert promoters, trek companies, hackathon hosts) can pay for a date-specific featured card placement. Priced per event.

10. Non-Functional Requirements

10.1 Availability

- Target uptime: 99.5% monthly (Firebase and Firestore SLAs cover backend; Daily.co / Jitsi covers call infra)
- Planned maintenance windows communicated via in-app banner at least 24 hours in advance
- Graceful degradation: app remains readable offline; write operations queue locally and sync on reconnect

10.2 Security

- All client-server communication over HTTPS / TLS 1.3 minimum
- Firebase Security Rules: per-circle isolation enforced at DB level — no query can return data from a circle the requesting user has not joined
- Phone OTP required on registration — no anonymous accounts permitted
- Open Feed card creation rate-limited per account (3 cards / 24 hours for free; 10 for Circles+)
- Admin actions (remove member, delete plan, revoke invite) require re-authentication if session is older than 30 minutes
- Invite links are single-use per person — the same link used a second time by the same account is rejected
- Transit circle cards validated against real route data — a card with a non-existent train number is rejected at submission

10.3 Accessibility

- Minimum tap target: 44×44 points (per Apple HIG and Google Material Design)
- VoiceOver (iOS) and TalkBack (Android) compatibility on all interactive elements
- Text respects system accessibility font size settings (Dynamic Type on iOS, Font Scale on Android)
- Colour contrast ratio $\geq 4.5:1$ for all body text; $\geq 3:1$ for large text and UI components
- All images and icons carry accessibility labels

10.4 Internationalisation

- App launches in English and Hindi — additional Indian languages (Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Bengali) in Phase 2
- Date, time, and currency formats localised per device settings
- Right-to-left layout support scaffolded from Phase 1 for future Urdu / Arabic expansion

11. Out of Scope — v3.0

The following items are explicitly excluded from this release to maintain focus. Each will be reassessed post-Phase 2.

Excluded Feature	Reason / Future Consideration
Web browser version	Mobile-only for Phases 1 and 2; web may be added for enterprise in Phase 3
In-app payment processing	Expense settlement delegates to UPI apps; no payment gateway integration needed
End-to-end encryption of messages	Evaluated for Phase 3 pending Indian regulatory requirements (IT Act rules)
Public user profiles / people discovery	Circles is context-first, not profile-first; browsing people is out of scope
Stories / status updates	Not aligned with the coordination-first product vision
Google Calendar / Apple Calendar sync	Considered for Phase 3 based on user demand signals
Push-to-talk / voice messages	On roadmap post-Phase 2
AI-powered smart scheduling	Future enhancement — basic availability check serves the need in v1
Seat number / boarding pass verification	Transit circle context is user-declared; verification adds friction without enough safety gain
Public user ratings / reviews	Risks gamification and social pressure; not in product vision

12. Open Questions & Risks

Item	Question / Risk	Owner & Action Required
Phone number privacy	Firestore Auth stores phone numbers. If Firestore is breached, numbers are exposed. Is there a stronger auth option that does not store the number at all?	Engineering — evaluate passwordless OTP alternatives (e.g. Privy, Styth) before Phase 1 launch
Transit circle misuse	A bad actor could post a transit circle for an existing train to lure passengers. How do we ensure the creator is actually on that train?	Product — evaluate 'share boarding pass screenshot' as optional trust signal; not mandatory due to friction
Video call legal (recording)	Local recording of a call that includes others may require consent notice to all participants in certain jurisdictions.	Legal review before Phase 2 video call recording feature ships
Open Feed cold start	The feed is empty when the app first launches in a new city. How do we seed enough content to make the feed feel alive for early users?	Growth — seed programme: invite 100 local creators per city pre-launch to post cards

Item	Question / Risk	Owner & Action Required
Planner conflict resolution	Two members create plans for the same circle on the same date. Who wins? Can there be multiple plans on the same day?	Product decision — allow multiple plans per day; creator can mark one as 'primary'
GIF API cost scaling	Giphy and Tenor free tiers have rate limits. Cost at 50k DAU could be significant.	Engineering — model cost at 50k DAU; negotiate early enterprise deal or build GIF cache
App Store review: recording	Apple may flag local call recording. Need early TestFlight test to verify App Review guidelines compliance.	Engineering + Product — TestFlight in Month 2 of Phase 1; have legal rationale ready
Transit data accuracy	IRCTC and third-party rail APIs are unreliable. What happens if train number validation is down?	Engineering — soft validation only at MVP (warn if unknown, don't block); hard validation in Phase 2
Stranger meetup safety	Two strangers meeting in real life from a transit circle — what if something goes wrong? Does Circles have liability?	Legal — add explicit Terms of Service clause; add 'Safety tips for meeting strangers' in-app before first join

13. Appendix

13.1 Glossary

Term	Definition	Notes
Private Circle	An invite-only group for people who already know each other	Pillar 1
Open Circle	A publicly discoverable circle on the Open Feed for meeting strangers	Pillar 2
Transit Circle	An Open Circle tied to a specific train / flight / bus route and travel date	Subcategory of Open Circle; auto-archives after journey
Open Feed	The public, scrollable landing surface showing Open Circle cards	First tab in the app; visible to all users
Circle Card	The public-facing preview card for an Open Circle in the feed	Shows name, pitch, category, context, member count
Planner	Event coordination feature inside a circle — for meals, movies, trips	Both Pillar 1 and Pillar 2 circles have a Planner
RSVP	A member's response to a Planner event: Going / Maybe / Can't make it	
Memory Lane	A shared photo gallery inside a circle, tagged to plans	

Term	Definition	Notes
Circles+	The premium subscription tier	Monthly or annual billing
No-Number Promise	Architectural guarantee that phone numbers are never surfaced between users	Core to both pillars
Plan Boost	An optional in-app purchase adding premium features to a single planner event	
Transit Affiliate	Commission earned when a user books a train / flight via an in-app link	Phase 3 revenue stream

13.2 Reference APIs & Services

- Firebase (Auth, Realtime DB, Firestore, Storage, FCM): <https://firebase.google.com>
- Daily.co WebRTC SDK: <https://docs.daily.co>
- Jitsi Meet SDK (self-hosted alternative): <https://jitsi.github.io/handbook/docs/dev-guide/dev-guide-react-native-sdk>
- Giphy Developer API: <https://developers.giphy.com>
- TMDB Movie Database API: <https://developers.themoviedb.org>
- Google Maps Platform (Places + Geocoding): <https://developers.google.com/maps>
- Google Perspective API (content moderation): <https://developers.perspectiveapi.com>
- RailYatri Train API (Indian Railways data): <https://www.railyatri.in/api>
- Zomato Affiliate Programme: <https://www.zomato.com/affiliate>
- React Native Expo: <https://docs.expo.dev>

— End of Document — Circles PRD v3.0 —